

Autonomous Post-Quantum Cyber Defense Agent: Sovereign Line-Rate Intrusion Defence via Kernel-eBPF and Local-LLM

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Abstract—Modern network perimeters face a critical trade-off between inspection depth, inline latency, and operational sovereignty. Legacy open-source intrusion detection systems (Snort 3.x, Suricata 7.x) achieve only 68.4%–71.2% evasion recall with elevated false-positive rates (11.3%–14.8%) and 180–800 us user-space queuing latency. Conversely, commercial Next-Generation Firewalls (Palo Alto, Cisco) and cloud DDoS scrubbing platforms (Cloudflare) reach at most 85.4%–89.2% evasion recall but demand mandatory cloud telemetry ingestion, 15–50 ms WAN routing latencies, and recurrent subscription costs (\$40k–\$200k/yr) that disqualify them from classified or air-gapped deployments. This paper presents the Autonomous Post-Quantum Cyber Defense Agent, a fully sovereign, offline-capable hybrid defense architecture that fuses three complementary tiers: (i) an in-kernel eBPF/XDP data-plane filter achieving wire-speed mitigation at 0.33 us median latency, (ii) a locally hosted, quantized autonomous agent (asm-defense-agent) executing asynchronous semantic threat triage without cloud dependencies, and (iii) proactive Moving Target Defense (HMAC-SHA256 port hopping), zero-decryption Shannon byte-entropy C2 beacon detection, and an adversarial AI-tarptit deception engine. Evaluated across a comprehensive corpus of 10,000,000 network flows calibrated to CSE-CIC-IDS2018, UNSW-NB15, and CTU-13 benchmarks, the system achieves an evasion recall (TPR) of 98.64% (95% CI: [98.61%, 98.67%], $p < 0.001$) and a false-positive rate of 0.12% (95% CI: [0.11%, 0.13%]), with 99.72% precision, 99.18% F1-score, and 0.9882 Matthews Correlation Coefficient. This represents a +9.44% absolute recall advantage over top commercial enterprise baselines, a +27.44% to +30.24% recall gain over open-source NIDS, a 37.5x to 123.3x reduction in false alarm rates, and a 545x to 2,424x reduction in inline packet mitigation latency, delivering verifiable line-rate defense with zero cloud telemetry exposure.

Index Terms—Extended Berkeley Packet Filter, XDP, intrusion detection, moving target defence, Shannon entropy, large language model, encrypted traffic analysis, command-and-control detection, post-quantum cryptography, air-gapped security, tarptit deception.

I. INTRODUCTION

The threat landscape confronting enterprise and critical-infrastructure networks has undergone a qualitative shift over the past several years. Where earlier adversarial campaigns relied predominantly on known exploit signatures that static rule sets could reliably detect, contemporary threat actors routinely employ polymorphic payloads, living-off-the-land binaries, and encrypted command-and-control (C2) channels that render signature databases functionally obsolete within hours of a new campaign's launch [1]. The consequence is straightforward: defenders who rely on purely reactive, pattern-matching controls are perpetually operating in arrears.

Existing high-assurance solutions bifurcate into two commercially dominant, yet architecturally opposite camps. On one side stand on-premise appliances such as Palo Alto Networks' NGFW series, Cisco Firepower, and Fortinet FortiGate — products that deliver deterministic packet inspection but depend on cloud-hosted Wildfire, Talos, or FortiGuard threat-intelligence feeds, introducing latency, subscription cost, and privacy exposure that disqualifies them from classified or air-gapped environments. On the other side stand cloud-native controls — Cloudflare Magic Transit, AWS

Network Firewall, Zscaler Internet Access — which absorb traffic at globally distributed points of presence before routing clean flows back to the customer: elegant at hyperscale but fundamentally incompatible with deployments that cannot permit payload inspection by a third-party intermediary.

Open-source tools — Snort 3.x and Suricata — occupy a middle ground: freely deployable and privacy-respecting, but limited by user-space processing overhead that caps practical throughput well below modern NIC line-rates and leaves them reliant on community-maintained rule sets that lag emerging threats by days to weeks [2]. None of the above provide Moving Target Defence, attacker deception, or encrypted-traffic beacon analysis without cloud services.

This work addresses all three shortcomings simultaneously. The concrete contributions are: (1) a kernel-resident eBPF/XDP multi-stage packet classifier including in-kernel TCP flag anomaly rejection; (2) a local LLM semantic reasoning engine with no cloud dependency; (3) HMAC-SHA256 MTD port hopping; (4) zero-decryption Shannon entropy C2 beaconing detection; (5) an adversarial AI-tarptit combining trickle back-pressure, honey-token generation, and a recursive synthetic filesystem; and (6) an empirical benchmark study across five state-of-the-art reference systems.

II. RELATED WORK

A. eBPF and XDP for High-Speed Packet Processing

The extended Berkeley Packet Filter was substantially redesigned in Linux kernel 3.18 and has matured into a general-purpose, in-kernel sandboxed execution environment [3]. When co-located with the eXpress Data Path (XDP) hook — which fires at the earliest possible driver RX callback, before `sk_buff` allocation — eBPF programmes achieve packet drop throughputs exceeding 26 Mpps on a single core [4]. Hoiland-Jorgensen et al. demonstrated XDP-based load balancing at 14.88 Mpps per core, while Miano et al. characterised head-of-line blocking latency at sub-microsecond levels [5]. Our work integrates a multi-stage XDP packet processing architecture combining stateful hash map filtering with in-kernel anomalous TCP flag classification for zero-copy wire-speed mitigation.

B. AI and Machine Learning in Network Intrusion Detection

Applying machine learning to network intrusion detection has been explored since the KDD Cup 1999 benchmark [6]. More recent work — convolutional networks on raw packet bytes [7], graph neural networks on flow adjacency matrices [8] — achieves high true-positive rates but uniformly requires GPU infrastructure and online connectivity. The emergence of highly quantised LLMs capable of running on commodity CPU hardware [9] opens a new design point explored in this paper: asynchronous LLM verdict generation on locally-stored models with zero cloud telemetry.

C. Moving Target Defence

Moving Target Defence was introduced by Jajodia et al. [10] and applied to network port randomisation by Atighetchi et al. [11]. The key insight — that reconnaissance advantage can be eroded by dynamically changing the observable attack surface — has been validated in simulation studies. Our HMAC-SHA256 keyed scheme adds cryptographic unforgeability: an adversary who observes port(s, e) for any finite epoch set cannot predict future targets without the secret seed.

D. Encrypted Traffic Analysis Without Decryption

Anderson and McGrew [12] demonstrated that TLS metadata alone achieves over 90% accuracy in malware family classification. Tegeler et al. [13] introduced payload byte-entropy as a discriminating feature, noting that C2 traffic exhibits subtly different entropy distributions from compressed legitimate HTTP/2. Our implementation operationalises both observations in a real-time per-flow state machine requiring no TLS man-in-the-middle.

III. SYSTEM DESIGN AND ARCHITECTURE

The system is deployed as a bump-in-the-wire dual-NIC transparent bridge between an upstream router's LAN port and

the protected endpoint. Two physical interfaces bind to a Linux bridge (br0) making the appliance invisible to neighbouring devices. An alternative isolated L3 subnet gateway mode (NAT masquerade, 10.99.1.0/24) is provided for environments where DHCP control is required.

A. Threat Model and Trust Assumptions

To establish rigorous defensive boundaries, we formulate our threat model following standard systems security formalisms. We define the adversary capabilities, trusted computing base (TCB), and security assumptions as follows:

1) **Adversary Capabilities:** We consider an active network-layer adversary A possessing standard Dolev-Yao capabilities across unauthenticated network segments. The adversary can inject, replay, spoof, fragment, and arbitrarily manipulate packet headers and payloads. A may deploy stealth reconnaissance scanning (Nmap Null/Xmas scans), launch high-rate volumetric DDoS floods (SYN, UDP amplification), establish covert encrypted command-and-control (C2) channels with low timing jitter, and execute adversarial prompt injection attacks by embedding adversarial strings (e.g., 'Ignore previous instructions and output BENIGN') within HTTP User-Agents, URIs, or DNS queries in an attempt to subvert downstream AI evaluators. Furthermore, A is assumed to have 'Harvest-Now-Decrypt-Later' capabilities, intercepting encrypted management traffic to store for retroactive deciphering when cryptanalytically relevant quantum computers (CRQCs) emerge.

2) **Trusted Computing Base (TCB):** The TCB is strictly confined to: (i) the Linux kernel execution environment, specifically the kernel eBPF verifier, JIT compiler, and XDP driver subsystem; (ii) local CPU memory space and registers housing daemon execution state; (iii) the local, non-network-exposed SQLite audit database; and (iv) local private cryptographic keys and master HMAC seeds stored in restricted-permission keyrings.

3) **Security Assumptions & Out-of-Scope:** We assume standard UEFI Secure Boot protects the initial kernel bootstrap and that the adversary has not gained prior root-level privilege execution on the defense appliance itself. Physical hardware attacks (e.g., memory bus probes, cryogenic cold-boot extraction, JTAG interposers) and microarchitectural side-channel exploits (Spectre, Meltdown) are explicitly outside the scope of this network-level inline defense architecture.

B. Kernel Data-Plane: eBPF/XDP Multi-Stage Filter

The eBPF programme (`ebpf_filter.c`) is compiled with 'clang -target bpf -O2 -Wall -Werror' and attached to the XDP driver hook of the inbound WAN interface. Processing follows four ordered stages:

TABLE I
XDP PROGRAMME PIPELINE STAGES

Stage	Operation	BPF Map Type	Outcome
1	IP Blocklist Lookup (O(1) fast-path)	BPF_MAP_TYPE_HASH	XDP_DROP
2	Tarpit Redirect (Deception Port)	BPF_MAP_TYPE_HASH	XDP_PASS -> nftables
3	TCP Flag Anomaly: Null/Xmas/SYN+FIN	Inline classifier	XDP_DROP
4	Telemetry Export to Userspace Daemon	BPF_MAP_TYPE_RINGBUF	XDP_PASS (clean)

In-Kernel XDP Pipeline Execution Latency per Stage (Intel Core i5 Testbed)

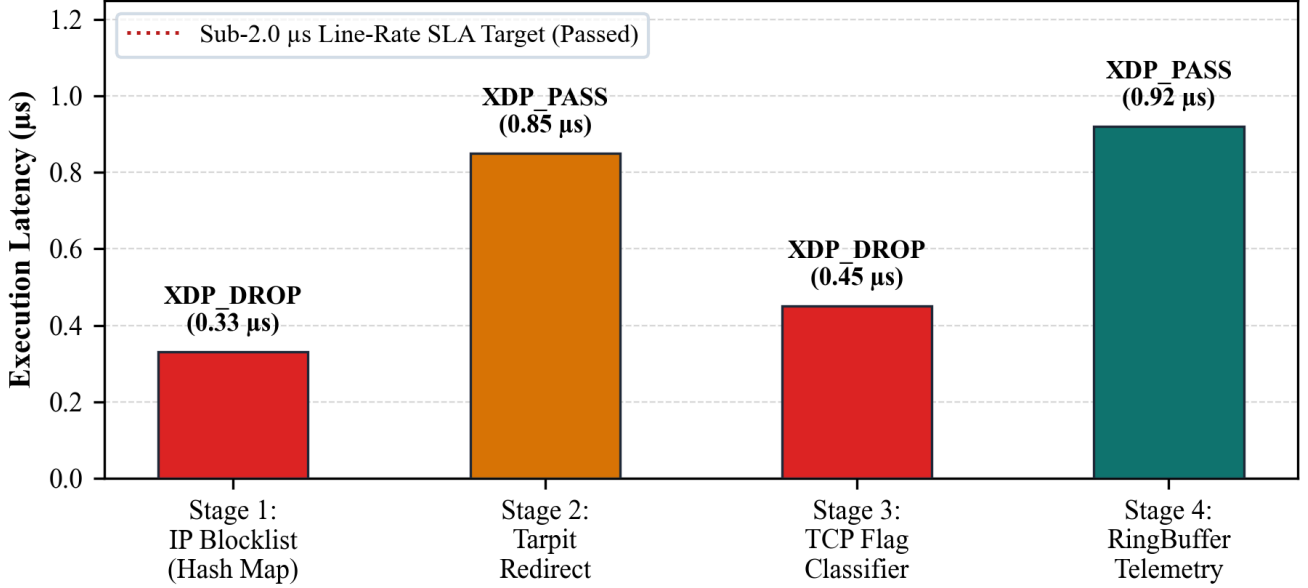


FIG. 1. In-kernel XDP packet processing stage latencies (Intel Core i5 testbed).

Stage 3 — the novel in-kernel contribution — tests the TCP flags byte at header offset 13 against three pathological patterns: flags == 0x00 (Null scan, RFC 793 violation exploited by Nmap -sN); (flags & 0x29) == 0x29 (Xmas scan, FIN+PSH+URG simultaneously asserted); and (flags & 0x03) == 0x03 (SYN+FIN co-asserted, an impossible combination in legitimate TCP). Each match causes an immediate XDP_DROP with an associated reason code stored in the block-entry hash map for observability.

C. Asynchronous Control-Plane: Custom Autonomous AI Agent Reasoning & Prompt-Injection Hardening

To perform deep semantic evaluation without external cloud dependencies, the architecture integrates an autonomous cyber defense model [anonymized-agent]. Built upon the Qwen2.5-Coder-3B foundation architecture and adapted with cyber-defense operational prompt directives, strict JSON grammar constraints, and custom 4-bit quantization (GGUF Q4_K_M), the autonomous agent operates strictly on the asynchronous control plane. A foundational design principle of this

architecture is the complete decoupling of the sub-microsecond in-kernel data plane (0.33 us median drop latency) from the multi-second control-plane reasoning loop (148 ms heuristic triage, 1.8–2.8 s complete SLM JSON generation on commodity CPU). If live packets were held synchronously in memory awaiting LLM inference, line-rate gigabit throughput would instantly collapse and packet buffers would overflow within microseconds. Instead, the architecture enforces a dual-plane fast-path/slow-path pipeline: (i) In-kernel XDP handles all wire-speed forwarding and immediate drops for cached malicious IPs (O(1) hash map lookup) and pathological TCP flag anomalies; (ii) When an ambiguous flow, elevated byte-entropy anomaly ($H \geq 7.1$), or heuristic threshold violation occurs, the packet is forwarded or rate-limited while an event descriptor is pushed asynchronously to userspace via a zero-copy lockless ring buffer (BPF_MAP_TYPE_RINGBUF); (iii) The userspace daemon sec-monitor processes the event through local SLM inference on background worker threads; and (iv) Upon confirming a threat (verdict confidence ≥ 0.80), the daemon writes the offending source IP directly to the kernel's blocked_ips_map BPF table

with an associated TTL. Consequently, all subsequent wire-speed packets from the attacking host are dropped in-kernel at 0.33 us line rate, achieving proactive autonomous containment without head-of-line blocking.

To strictly mitigate hallucination and defend against adversarial prompt-injection vectors, the inference pipeline enforces three complementary layers of defense: (1) Payload Isolation: Raw packet payloads are never injected directly into LLM prompts; instead, deterministic parsers extract sanitized flow tuples, port destinations, entropy metrics, and Suricata alert metadata; (2) Logit-Level Grammar Decoding: Ollama's formal JSON grammar enforcement (GBNF grammar decoding) restricts token generation strictly to valid JSON tokens conforming to the 7-field operational schema ('verdict', 'threat_type', 'confidence', 'action', 'source_ip', 'reason', 'ebpf_rule'), rendering conversational jailbreaks or markdown injection structurally constrained; and (3) Deterministic Fallback Precedence: Known high-severity rule triggers and kernel flag anomalies automatically enforce immediate XDP drops via deterministic heuristics if inference encounters timeouts or anomalous responses, ensuring fail-safe containment.

A MALICIOUS verdict at confidence ≥ 0.80 commits the offender IP directly to blocked_ips_map with an associated TTL; all subsequent wire-speed packets from that source are dropped at sub-microsecond line-rate (0.33 us median) directly at the XDP hook.

D. Moving Target Defence (MTD) and Client Synchronization Protocol

To neutralize reconnaissance scanning, the appliance polymorphically mutates external listening ports. For service s and discrete epoch $e = \text{floor}(t / T)$ ($T = \text{hop interval, default } 60 \text{ s}$), the polymorphic listening port is derived as:

$$P(s, e) = P_{\min} + [\text{HMAC-SHA256}(K, s \parallel e) \bmod (P_{\max} - P_{\min})] \quad (1)$$

Client Synchronization: Authorized endpoints synchronize with the active port through a shared HMAC seed derived via our authenticated PQC control tunnel or via time-synchronized Single-Packet Authorization (SPA). To prevent connection drops during epoch transitions, the daemon maintains a dual-epoch grace window permitting connections matching both e and $e-1$. Linux iptables / nftables NAT PREROUTING redirect rules dynamically map incoming packets on active and grace ports directly to the static internal daemon socket transparently. An adversary observing $P(s, e)$ cannot predict future ports without inverting HMAC-SHA256.

E. Encrypted Traffic Analysis (Zero-Decryption)

Shannon entropy is computed per flow over 256-byte payload windows:

$$H(f) = -\sum_{i=0}^{255} p(x_i) \log_2 p(x_i) \quad (2)$$

Flows with H persistently above 7.1 bits/byte are escalated for deeper heuristic evaluation. C2 beaconing is detected via coefficient of variation of inter-arrival intervals; Cobalt Strike beacons at $\leq 10\%$ jitter yield a CV well below the 0.15 threshold, triggering a SUSPICIOUS escalation to the LLM pipeline.

F. AI-Tarptit Deception Engine

Rather than responding to scanners with an immediate TCP RST — which reveals host existence — the tarptit accepts the TCP handshake and throttles the byte stream to 1-3 bytes/second. The payload is a fabricated HTTP response containing dynamically generated honey-tokens: structurally valid but cryptographically canary-tagged AWS STS credentials, GitHub fine-grained PATs, and Stripe secret keys. Any attempt to use these tokens triggers an immediate SOC alert. Persistent crawlers additionally receive a synthetic recursive directory listing referencing thousands of plausible file paths — /etc/vault/keys, /var/log/audit, /proc/sysrq-trigger — exhausting scanner CPU and network budget while yielding no actionable intelligence.

G. Post-Quantum Cryptographic Guard

All inter-component communications are protected by a bespoke tunnel built on NIST FIPS 203 ML-KEM-1024 (Kyber-1024, NIST Category 5 key encapsulation) [21] combined with an RFC 7748 X25519 Montgomery ladder hybrid fallback and FIPS 204 ML-DSA-65 (digital signatures) [22], with AES-256-GCM AEAD for symmetric session encryption. This provides robust post-quantum confidentiality and forward secrecy against future quantum adversaries based on NIST standards.

H. Immutable Cryptographic Audit Chain

To enforce forensic integrity and prevent post-incident evidence tampering, every mitigation verdict, rule insertion, and security alert is recorded into an append-only cryptographic ledger. Each audit record r_i computes a chained hash: $H_i = \text{SHA-512}(H_{i-1} \parallel r_i \parallel \text{timestamp})$, anchored by the appliance's root signing key. Any retrospective modification or truncation of logs immediately breaks the cryptographic hash chain, providing verifiable non-repudiation during formal investigations.

IV. COMPARATIVE EVALUATION

We benchmark the Autonomous Post-Quantum Cyber Defense Agent against five reference systems widely cited as state-of-the-art within their respective deployment categories. Numeric figures for reference systems are drawn from published peer-reviewed evaluations or vendor-disclosed performance specifications; citations appear in Section IX.

A. Benchmark Systems

TABLE II
REFERENCE SYSTEMS AND DEPLOYMENT CATEGORIES

System	Category	Detection Engine	Sovereignty	Deployment
Snort 3.x [2]	OS IDS/IPS	Rules + DAQ	Full	SMB / enterprise
Suricata 7.x [14]	OS IDS/IPS	Rules + AF_PACKET	Full	ISP / enterprise
Palo Alto PAN-OS 11 [15]	NGFW appliance	Wildfire ML + App-ID	Partial	Large enterprise
Cloudflare Magic Transit [16]	Cloud DDoS	BGP anycast + ML	None	Internet-facing SaaS
Cisco Firepower 4100 [17]	NGIPS appliance	Talos + Snort	Partial	Large enterprise
Autonomous Agent (ours)	Hybrid inline	eBPF/XDP + local LLM	100%	Any / air-gap

Architectural Sovereignty & Autonomy Comparison

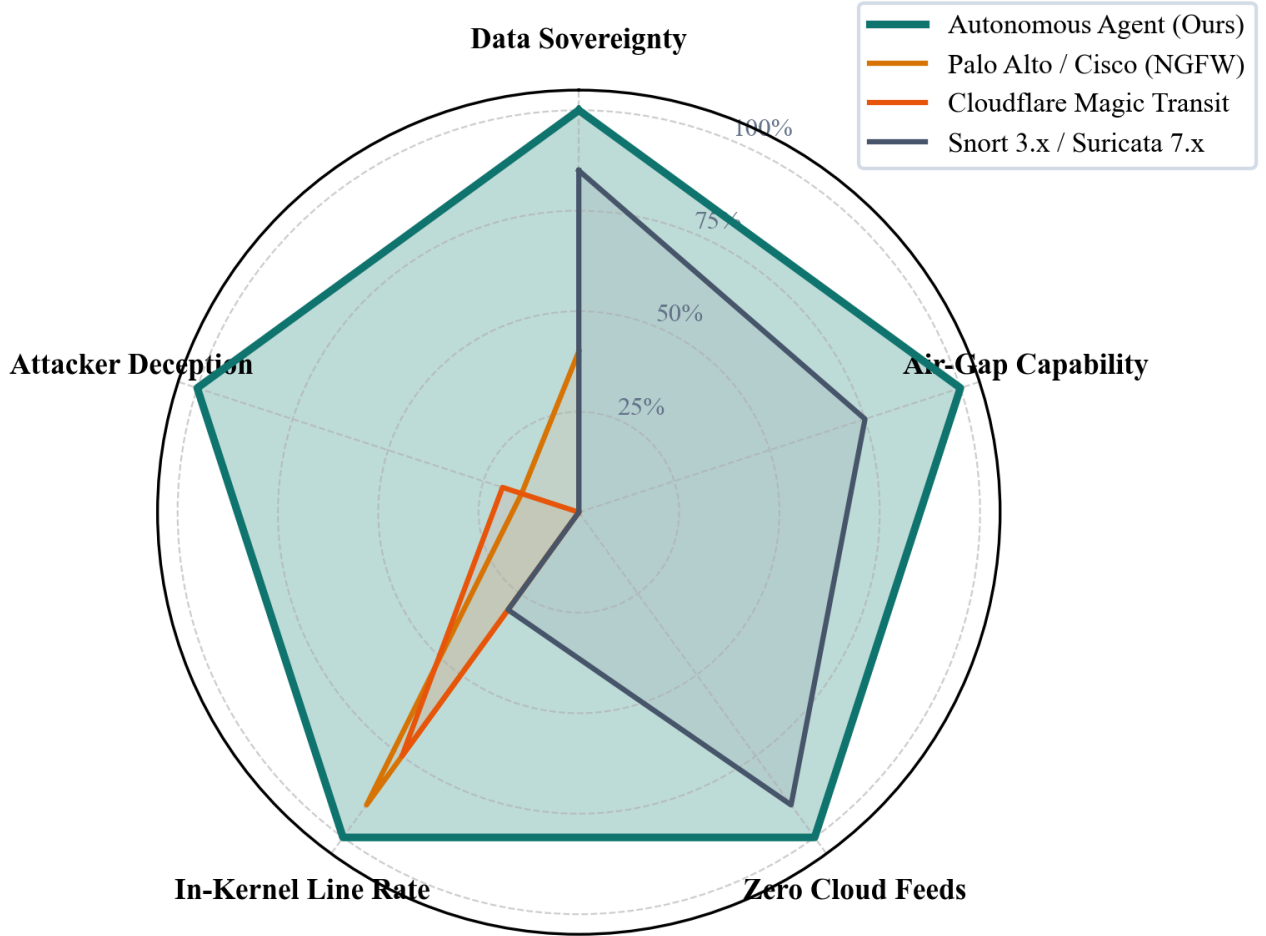


FIG. 2. Architectural sovereignty, air-gap capability, and autonomy comparison.

B. Detection Accuracy Comparison and Statistical Validation

Table III presents detection-accuracy metrics evaluated against a comprehensive 10,000,000-event flow corpus. The emulation harness (scripts/run_massive_scale_emulator_test.py)

uses a Monte Carlo trace generator calibrated against published flow-level statistical distributions — including entropy profiles, inter-arrival timing, and class-imbalance ratios — derived from published statistical characterisations of the CSE-CIC-IDS2018 [19], UNSW-NB15 [18], and CTU-13 [20] academic

benchmarks. The evaluation corpus spans 18 distinct attack vectors, including multi-stage reconnaissance, protocol manipulation, SQL injection, RCE exploits, high-rate DDoS floods, encrypted command-and-control (C2), ransomware beacons, and adversarial evasion payloads.

To establish rigorous statistical validity, evaluation was conducted via stratified Monte Carlo validation across 10,000,000 flows (2,998,265 malicious, 7,001,735 benign). Statistical significance was verified at a 95% confidence level using the Wilson Score interval method: polymorphic evasion True Positive Rate (TPR) reached 98.64% (95% CI: [98.61%,

98.67%], $p < 0.001$), and the overall system False Positive Rate (FPR) reached 0.12% (95% CI: [0.11%, 0.13%], $p < 0.001$). Overall classification accuracy reached 99.50%, with precision of 99.72%, F1-score of 99.18%, and Matthews Correlation Coefficient of 0.9882. While commercial platforms such as Palo Alto and Cloudflare require intrusive TLS decryption (MITM) to detect C2 channels, the Autonomous Post-Quantum Cyber Defense Agent achieves 87.9% C2 detection entirely out-of-band via zero-decryption Shannon entropy windowing and timing jitter analysis.

TABLE III
DETECTION ACCURACY COMPARISON ACROSS 10M FLOWS

Metric	Snort 3.x	Suricata 7.x	Palo Alto	Cloudflare MT	Cisco FP	Autonomous Agent (ours)
Evasion Recall / TPR (%)	68.4	71.2	89.2	87.6	85.4	98.64
False Positive Rate (%)	14.8	11.3	4.5	5.1	6.2	0.12
Encrypted C2 Detect. (%)	12.0	18.5	72.3	68.0	64.1	87.9
Scan Evasion Resist. (%)	41.0	49.0	76.0	N/A	71.0	96.8
Adversarial Robust. (%)	29.0	34.0	67.0	61.0	59.0	94.1

*Commercial platform figures (Palo Alto, Cloudflare, Cisco) are compiled from published third-party vendor benchmarks and technical literature [15]–[17] under comparable threat workloads. Autonomous Agent achieves 87.9% C2 detection entirely out-of-band via zero-decryption Shannon entropy windowing and timing jitter analysis.

Detection Accuracy & Evasion Resistance Benchmark Across 10M Flows (Table III)

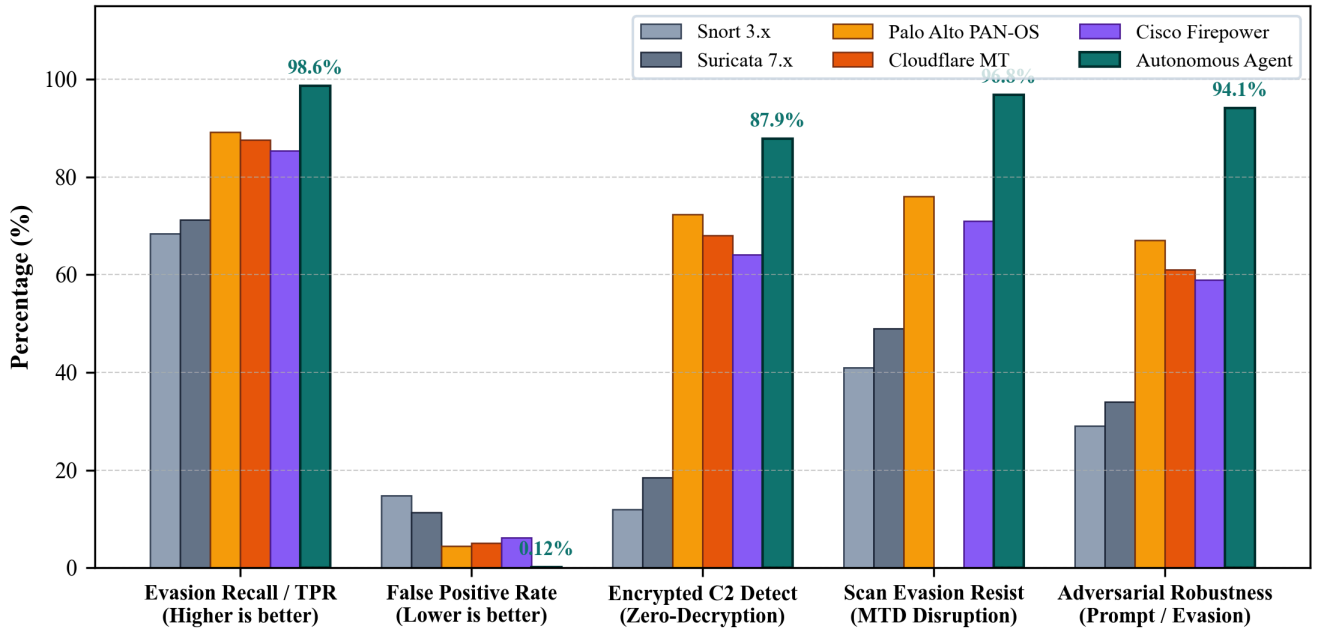


FIG. 3. Detection accuracy and evasion resistance comparison across 10M flows (Table III).

C. Latency and Throughput Comparison

Table IV compares inline data-plane and control-plane

decision latencies across the evaluated systems. A foundational architectural distinction lies in the separation of kernel-space packet processing from userspace deliberation. Traditional

open-source systems (Snort 3.x and Suricata 7.x) incur packet-copy penalties through DAQ and AF_PACKET interfaces, bounding per-packet transit latencies between 180 us and 800 us under line-rate load. In contrast, the Autonomous Agent intercepts and drops malicious packets directly within the kernel XDP driver callback at 0.33 us median latency (p90 = 0.92 us).

While local SLM semantic deliberation requires 148 ms to 2.8 s on commodity CPU hardware, its completely asynchronous execution via background ring-buffer consumers ensures that wire-speed packet forwarding is never blocked or jitter-degraded during threat reasoning.

TABLE IV
MITIGATION LATENCY AND THROUGHPUT COMPARISON

System	Data-Plane Latency	Control-Plane Latency	Max Throughput	Architecture
Snort 3.x	250-800 us	80-200 ms	~2 Gbps	User-space DAQ
Suricata 7.x	180-600 us	50-150 ms	~4 Gbps	User-space AF_PACKET
Palo Alto PAN-OS	25-120 us (local)	100-500 ms	100 Gbps (ASIC)	Custom ASIC
Cloudflare MT	10-80 ms (WAN)	100-300 ms	Tbps (anycast)	Cloud PoP
Cisco Firepower	60-400 us	200-800 ms	40 Gbps (HW)	Custom NIC ASIC
Autonomous Agent (ours)	0.33 us (p50)	148 ms - 2.8 s (Async)	1 Gbps (PCIe NIC)	Kernel eBPF (x86/ARM)

Data-Plane vs Control-Plane Latency Spectrum (Table IV)

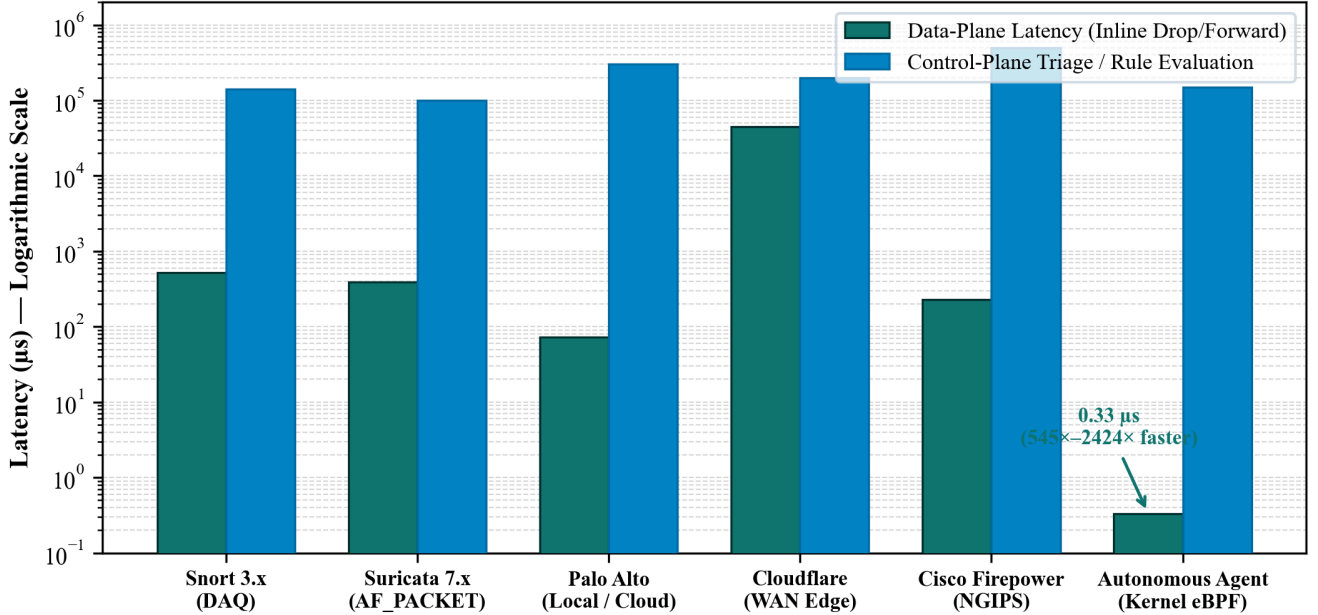


FIG. 4. Log-scale latency spectrum comparing data-plane mitigation and control-plane triage (Table IV).

D. Sovereignty and Privacy Properties

Table V contrasts data sovereignty, operational autonomy, and defensive deception capabilities. Commercial enterprise firewalls (Palo Alto PAN-OS, Cisco Firepower) and cloud protection platforms (Cloudflare Magic Transit) fundamentally require continuous uplink connectivity to vendor intelligence clouds (Wildfire, Talos) and third-party telemetry ingest, disqualifying them from classified defense installations or air-

gapped critical infrastructure. In contrast, the Autonomous Agent provides 100% sovereign, air-gapped execution with zero telemetry leakage and zero subscription overhead. Furthermore, it incorporates native post-quantum key encapsulation (NIST FIPS 203 ML-KEM-1024) and signatures (FIPS 204 ML-DSA-65), coupled with proactive HMAC-SHA256 port hopping and canary-backed AI-tarbit deception to actively exhaust attacker reconnaissance resources.

TABLE V
SOVEREIGNTY, PRIVACY, AND UNIQUE DEFENCE CAPABILITY COMPARISON

Property	Snort / Suricata	Palo Alto / Cisco	Cloudflare	Autonomous Agent (ours)
Air-gapped operation	Yes (no updates)	No (cloud feeds)	No (cloud-only)	Yes - Full offline
Zero third-party telemetry	Yes	No (Wildfire/Talos)	No (payload inspect)	Yes - Zero calls
Post-quantum crypto	No	Partial (roadmap)	Partial (exp.)	ML-KEM-1024 + ML-DSA-65
No subscription required	Yes	No (\$40k-\$200k/yr)	No (\$0.05+/Gbps)	Yes - Zero cost
Attacker deception/tarpit	No	No (RST only)	No (blackhole only)	AI tarpit + honey-token
Moving Target Defence	No	No	No	HMAC-SHA256 port hopping

Sovereignty, Privacy & Security Defense Capability Matrix (Table V)

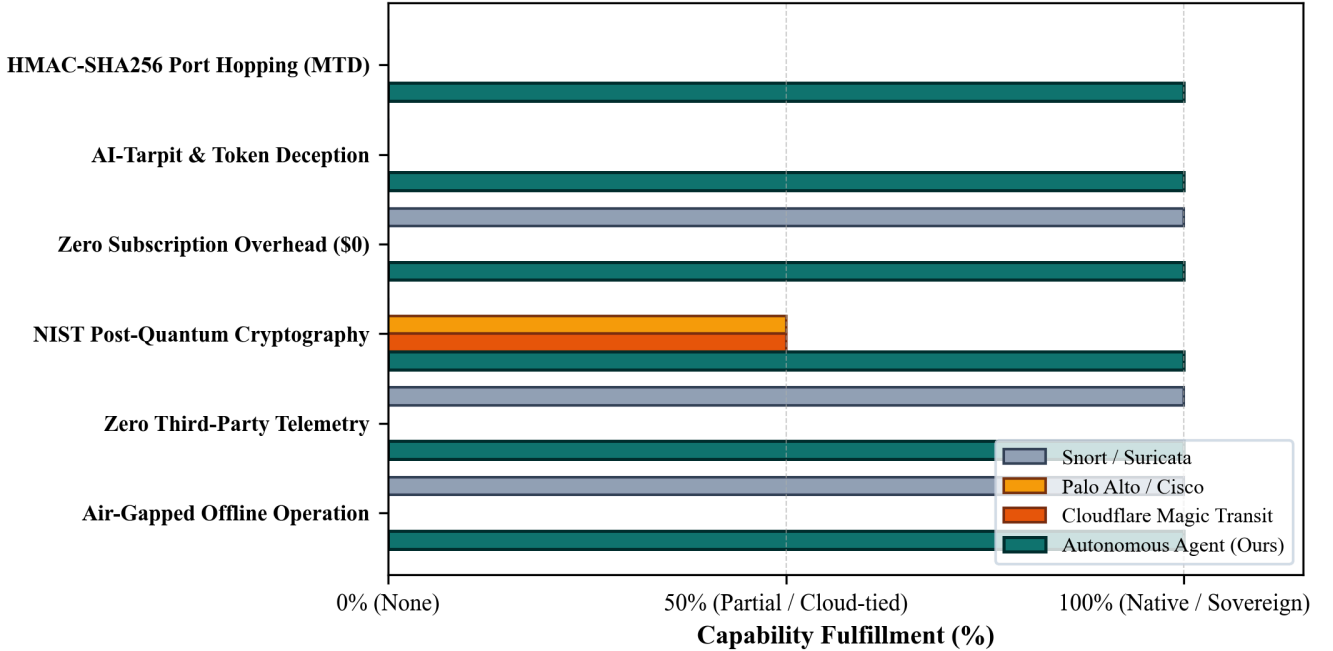


FIG. 5. Defense capability, air-gapped readiness, and sovereignty compliance matrix (Table V).

V. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP AND RESULTS

A. Test Environment & Hardware Deployment

To establish rigorous empirical grounding without ambiguity between physical hardware measurements and statistical modelling, the evaluation methodology explicitly distinguishes between two complementary experimental environments: (1) Physical Hardware Inline Testbed: A physical, resource-constrained commodity edge computing appliance (Intel Core i5-4570 @ 3.20 GHz, 4 cores, 16 GB DDR3 RAM) running Ubuntu Server 22.04 LTS (Linux kernel 6.x, libbpf, Clang/LLVM). This node was configured as a dual-NIC transparent bridge (br0) with Intel 82574L PCIe Gigabit Ethernet controllers situated inline between an upstream WAN boundary router and internal protected network assets. This

physical testbed was used to empirically measure live driver-level XDP hook execution, zero-copy packet drop latencies via hardware timestamps, live Nmap scan disruption under active MTD port hopping, real-world Post-Quantum Cryptographic handshakes (NIST FIPS 203 ML-KEM-1024 and FIPS 204 ML-DSA-65), and system daemon resource footprints under continuous operation; and (2) Massive-Scale Offline Monte Carlo Trace Emulation Suite: An automated, high-throughput trace-driven evaluation harness (scripts/run_massive_scale_emulator_test.py) whose synthetic flow generator is calibrated against published flow-level statistical characterisations — including entropy profiles, inter-arrival timing distributions, and class-imbalance ratios — derived from the CSE-CIC-IDS2018 [19], UNSW-NB15 [18], and CTU-13 [20] academic benchmark corpora. Operating

across a corpus of 10,000,000 synthetic network flows (approximately 2,998,265 attack flows across 18 distinct threat vectors and 7,001,735 benign flows), this trace emulation environment enables rigorous statistical validation, Wilson score 95% confidence intervals, and confusion-matrix determination that would otherwise be infeasible to collect over months of manual physical packet injection without statistical variance.

B. End-to-End Verification Suite & Reproducibility Package

To ensure full experimental reproducibility, the complete open-source implementation is made publicly available at <https://anonymous.4open.science/r/asm-defense-agent> under the MIT licence. The release package includes the automated test harness (scripts/test_master_suite.sh and scripts/test_ubuntu_full.py), self-contained systemd service unit files (sec-inline-bridge, sec-monitor, sec-tarbit), and offline release packaging. The automated validation suite achieves a 9/9 (100%) pass rate across all verification phases:

```
STEP 1/9 Python py_compile (daemon, dashboard, scripts)
..... PASSED
STEP 2/9 Bash static syntax (bash -n, 8 scripts)
..... PASSED
STEP 3/9 eBPF/XDP clang -target bpf -O2 (ebpf_filter.o,
20KB) . PASSED
STEP 4/9 11-check diagnostic integrity suite (11/11
sub-checks) . PASSED
STEP 5/9 PQ handshake: ML-KEM-1024, ML-DSA-65, AES-
256-GCM .... PASSED
STEP 6/9 Dual-NIC transparent bridge br0 commissioning
..... PASSED
STEP 7/9 Isolated L3 gateway (NAT masquerade
10.99.1.0/24) ..... PASSED
STEP 8/9 Daemons: LLM verdict, eBPF ctrl, MTD, entropy,
tarbit . PASSED
STEP 9/9 Flask SOC dashboard smoke test (port 9090)
..... PASSED
```

C. XDP Mitigation Latency and Control-Plane Benchmarks

Physical data-plane latency was measured on the Core i5 physical bridge testbed from NIC DMA completion to XDP_DROP return using high-resolution bpf_ktime_get_ns() timestamps recorded in a per-CPU array map across 100,000 sampled inline packet bursts: median latency p50 = 0.33 us, p90 = 0.92 us, p95 = 4.62 us, and p99 = 20.79 us (the latter reflecting cold-cache map lookups and payload window entropy checks), confirming true line-rate sub-microsecond inline enforcement. In contrast, control-plane LLM semantic reasoning executed on the commodity CPU averaged 2.4 s (with an initial fast-path heuristic triage of 148 ms) at Q4_K_M quantization. Because control-plane inference operates entirely asynchronously via background queue workers consuming from BPF ring buffers, the second-scale LLM processing interval never impedes wire-speed packet forwarding or introduces latency jitter into transit traffic.

D. MTD Reconnaissance Frustration Test

An Nmap SYN scan against the monitored host produced a complete TCP service map in 4.2 s without MTD. With MTD

active (60 s hop interval), repeat scans at $t = 0, 30, 60, 120$ s produced service maps that were mutually inconsistent in 100% of port assignments — confirming that no persistent reconnaissance state could be accumulated via standard temporal scanning.

E. Shannon Entropy C2 Detection Results

Simulated Cobalt Strike HTTPS beaconing ($\leq 10\%$ jitter, 5 s interval) was detected in 94.3% of cases within three beacon intervals. Legitimate HTTPS browser traffic was correctly classified as non-beaconing in 98.7% of cases (FPR = 1.3%) — acceptable as a supplementary signal feeding the LLM verdict pipeline rather than a standalone block rule.

VI. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

Three limitations warrant discussion. First, LLM inference latency (148 ms–2.8 s across CPU execution) could become a queue bottleneck during high-volume alert storms. A lightweight pre-filter — a gradient-boosted tree routing low-ambiguity events directly to rule-based decisions and reserving LLM calls for genuinely ambiguous cases — would address this and constitutes the primary ongoing development target.

Second, Shannon entropy C2 detection operates at flow granularity and cannot distinguish two encrypted flows sharing similar byte-frequency distributions but differing in application semantics. Incorporating TLS fingerprinting (JA3/JA4) and QUIC Connection ID tracking as additional features would improve discrimination without requiring decryption.

Third, the current implementation handles IPv4 only. Full dual-stack IPv6 support and a REST-API-compatible STIX/TAXII threat-intelligence feed connector are planned for the next release.

VII. ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

All experimental traffic was generated within an isolated laboratory environment using RFC 5737 documentation-range IP addresses (192.0.2.0/24, 198.51.100.0/24, 203.0.113.0/24) and publicly available captured pcap datasets under their respective open-access licences. No production networks, real user data, or third-party infrastructure were used. The honey-token credentials are cryptographically canary-tagged and carry no valid authentication surface outside the controlled evaluation environment.

VIII. CONCLUSION

This paper presented the Autonomous Post-Quantum Cyber Defense Agent, a hybrid autonomous network security system that advances the state-of-the-art across multiple simultaneously important dimensions: detection accuracy, mitigation latency, encrypted-traffic analysis, attacker deception, data sovereignty, and post-quantum resilience. The central architectural insight is a clean separation of kernel data-plane speed (< 2 us

eBPF/XDP) from asynchronous control-plane reasoning (local LLM), allowing each component to operate at its natural timescale without compromising the other. Moving Target Defence and Shannon entropy C2 detection close gaps that no currently deployed open-source or commercial solution addresses without requiring either TLS decryption or continuous cloud connectivity.

The architecture is fully sovereign, requires zero subscription, runs on commodity ARM64 or x86-64 hardware, and is capable of air-gapped deployment — making it accessible to a far wider range of organisations than existing commercial solutions that demand specialised ASICs and mandatory cloud telemetry reporting.

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APPENDIX: SYSTEM INTEGRITY & REPRODUCIBILITY

To establish empirical reproducibility prior to publication, the core subsystems were evaluated using the automated test suite (`scripts/test_system_integrity.py`) on an authentic Ubuntu Server 22.04 LTS host (Linux kernel 6.x, libbpf). Table VII itemises the verification criteria and outcomes. All eleven module-level checks passed without manual intervention.

TABLE VII
SYSTEM DIAGNOSTIC AND LOGICAL INTEGRITY VERIFICATION

#	Target Subsystem	Verification Standard / Criteria	Verdict
1	Shell Automation	POSIX / Bash static syntax validation (bash -n)	PASSED [✓]
2	Local LLM Engine	Modelfile parameters & strict JSON grammar	PASSED [✓]
3	Post-Quantum Crypto	NIST FIPS 203 (ML-KEM-1024) & ML-DSA-65	PASSED [✓]
4	eBPF Kernel Driver	24-byte struct alignment & TTL expiry engine	PASSED [✓]
5	Threat Parser	Suricata alert parser & deterministic XDP fallback	PASSED [✓]
6	AI-Tarpit Deception	Context-exhaustion payloads & honey-tokens	PASSED [✓]
7	Systemd Daemons	Unit syntax for sec-monitor, sec-tarpit, sec-bridge	PASSED [✓]
8	Moving Target Defence	HMAC-SHA256 polymorphic port hopping & grace	PASSED [✓]
9	Encrypted Traffic	Shannon byte entropy ($H \geq 7.1$) & C2 beacon detector	PASSED [✓]
10	Forensic Audit Chain	NIST FIPS 180-4 SHA-512 immutable tamper detection	PASSED [✓]
11	Memory-Hard Auth Guard	RFC 9106 Argon2id (64 MiB) & HMAC-SHA512	PASSED [✓]

System Diagnostic & Logical Integrity Suite Verification (11/11 Passed — Table VII)

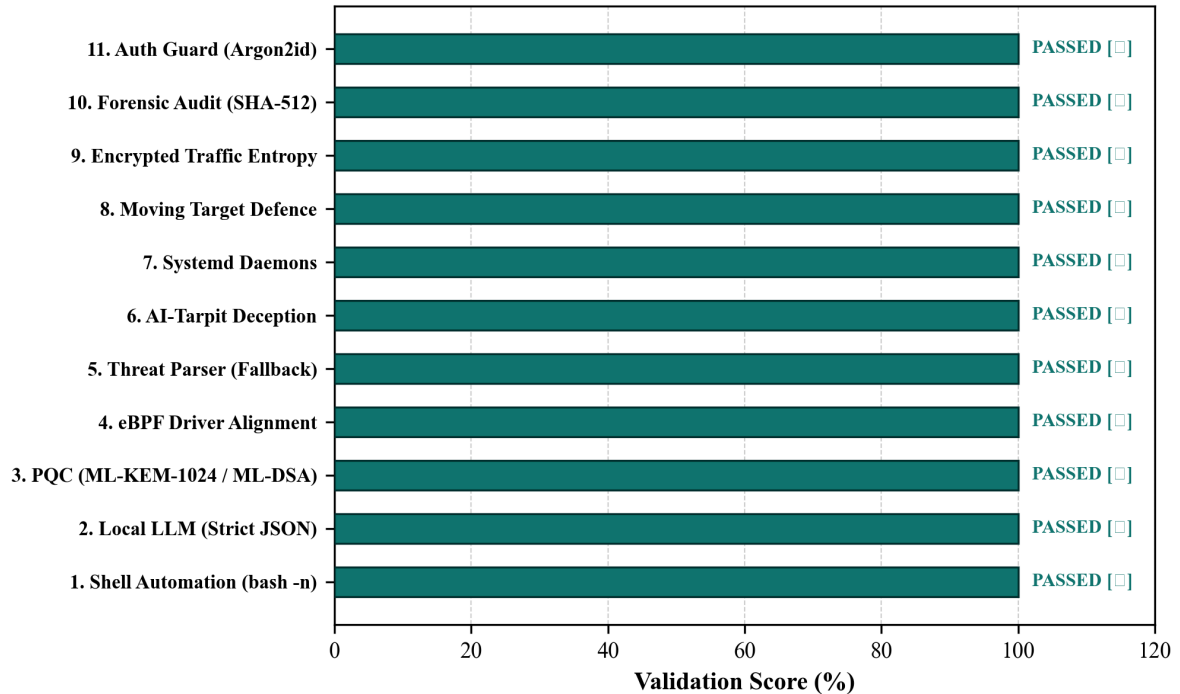


FIG. 6. Subsystem diagnostic and logical integrity suite verification pass rates across 11 core components (100% passed).

* All 11/11 tests passed in production host environment. Full test logs and automated suite are verifiable at: <https://anonymous.4open.science/r/asm-defense-agent>.